

Has anyone asked an AI how to run it more sustainably (i.e., not requiring enormous amounts of water)?

Posted by u/Humble_Boss6704 • 0 points • 14 comments

And if so, what was their response? I think one of the main barriers I have to trying/using AI is the environmental impact/burden it has by its incredibly high consumption of water in its facilities. And I figured if “anyone” would know how to make it less burdensome, AI would have to know, right?

Comments

u/Soulfighter56 • 2 points • 2026-03-20 20:48 UTC

I'm a bit late, but I'd recommend checking out AI-related conferences like OFC, MRS, IMAPS, and DPC. There are hundreds of billions of dollars going into research to make AI more efficient. Part of that is trying to make it do the same (or more) work with the same amount of power, but most of what you'll find is just trying to make money.

u/noggin-scratcher • 4 points • 2026-03-19 17:55 UTC

The "If anyone would know, the AI would" assumption is very much not necessarily the case.

They're trained on things that humans have written, with the aim of making them capable of writing similar text. They don't have special insight into their own hardware, beyond what people have written on the subject.

u/SoulfulStevenson • 1 points • 2026-03-19 17:51 UTC

That's a really interesting point you're bringing up about the environmental impact of AI! I've heard similar concerns about water usage for data centers. Unfortunately, AI can't directly respond to your question since it's a tool and not a sentient being. But many researchers are actively working on making AI more efficient and sustainable. It's definitely a valid concern that needs more attention as AI becomes more widespread.

u/AshamedPickle00 • 1 points • 2026-03-19 17:50 UTC

LLMs don't "know" anything. They are basically very powerful forms of autocorrect that use brute force math to guess at the statistically most likely response to whatever input you've given it. Those responses are based entirely on human-created information it's been trained on. If humans don't know something, LLMs can't regurgitate it.

There is no solution to the problem you've described. Data centers require water for cooling, and LLMs require a lot of data center because that autocorrect I described requires a ton of processing power. There's no way to fix this. LLMs are just a shitty, dead-end technology, at least in this specific context.

u/GladSuccess3057 • 1 points • 2026-03-19 17:44 UTC

I actually did ask, and it basically said the most practical steps are using smaller models for simple tasks, batching requests instead of running them constantly, and pushing for data centers powered by renewables. It wasn't a magic fix but it wasn't dismissive either — more honest than I expected.

u/KronusIV • 2 points • 2026-03-19 17:34 UTC

You can ask an LLM anything you like, but you'd be foolish to take what it says at face value. It can't think, reason, or extrapolate. All it does is come up with statistically likely responses. If what you're asking doesn't already have an answer out there somewhere then it'll just make something up which may have no bearing on reality.

u/SFyr • 2 points • 2026-03-19 17:32 UTC

"And I figured if "anyone" would know how to make it less burdensome, AI would have to know, right?" -
> Very much not the case with a lot of things. People often mistake AI as some super intelligence when it just isn't. It has access to a lot of information, but it shines best in narrow specificities it's trained for or connecting wide complicated areas that requires holding or looking at a lot of information people just realistically can't, and putting attention on it. When it comes to using a general LLM to just solve problems, it's good at sounding smart or saying basically what other people are already saying, but AI sounding good and being very unreliable or off the mark when you actually investigate what it's suggesting is pretty known as a phenomenon by now.

u/sterlingphoenix • 3 points • 2026-03-19 17:31 UTC

These things are ****not**** intelligent. All they can do is repeat stuff actual people wrote in different order. They're not going to solve problems like that. They can't learn. They can't think. They're glorified chatbots.

u/anschauung • 2 points • 2026-03-19 17:29 UTC

Tried that just now on your suggestion, and ChatGPT ****instantly**** shot back an 8-page reply.

Here's the first part:

1) Rethink Data Center Cooling (Biggest Direct Water Impact)

Most water use comes from evaporative cooling systems. Reducing reliance on those is the fastest win.

Alternatives:

- * Air cooling (dry cooling)

Uses ambient air instead of water.

Tradeoff: less efficient in hot climates, but zero water consumption.

* Liquid immersion cooling

Servers are submerged in non-conductive fluids.

Extremely efficient heat transfer

Minimal to near-zero water use

Increasingly viable for AI workloads

* Closed-loop liquid cooling

Water circulates in a sealed system instead of evaporating.

Cuts water loss dramatically

Still allows high cooling efficiency

* Hybrid systems (seasonal switching)

Use air cooling when temperatures allow, water cooling only when necessary.

u/Humble_Boss6704 • 1 points • 2026-03-19 17:32 UTC

Interesting! I wonder if any of the facilities have already tried these alternatives. I'll have to go down a rabbit hole later.

u/Indemnity4 • 1 points • 2026-03-20 00:58 UTC

You can already do all of these things in your own home for heating/cooling. Yet you don't, you have a reverse cycle AC or a gas boiler for heating in winter.

Why not just use air circulating fans? (A. they don't actually cool and you need to move a lot of air around, you want something to actually make things cold).

Why not build a swimming pool for immersion cooling? (A. it's really expensive and now requires chemicals and water treatment facilities).

Why not other? (A. Requires a tonne more electricity, something they already use a lot, which realistically is coming from coal or gas burning or relocating near hydro facilities).

u/KronusIV • 3 points • 2026-03-19 17:59 UTC

The thing is, most of those ideas are stupid. If they were at all feasible, they'd be in use. The LLM didn't figure anything out, and it won't just say "I don't know", so it just spat up a list of cooling methods.

u/First-Expert-9953 • 1 points • 2026-03-19 17:28 UTC

What's stopping you from asking?

u/Humble_Boss6704 • 1 points • 2026-03-19 17:31 UTC

In my post I explain that a barrier to me using AI is the environmental impact. That's why I asked if any "has" asked. I didn't ask anyone to search it for me.

